STATE EFFORTS IN KEY NAXAL-AFFECTED AREAS

SECURITY BOOST

- Security-related expenditure since 2014 ₹3,681 cr.
- Fortified police stations since 2014: 656
- Security camps set up since 2020: 406

INFRASTRUCTURE DEVELOPMENT

- Expenditure on new roads since 2014 ₹20,815 cr.
- Length of roads constructed: 12,000 km
- Mobile towers: 5,000

FINANCIAL INCLUSION

- Bank branches set up since 2014: 1,804
- New ATMs built: 1,321
- New post offices set up: 6,025

EDUCATIONAL EMPOWERMENT

- Eklavya Model Schools built: 259
- New Industrial Training Institutes opened: 46
- New Skill Development Centres built: 49

and logistics. According to Shah, over 92 per cent of the sophisticated, semi-automatic and automatic weapons in the Naxal arsenal were looted from security forces. By plugging ammunition leakages—critical since it is not freely available—agencies curtailed the ability of cadres to replenish their stocks.

This also drew on earlier models from the south. Officials in Andhra Pradesh and Telangana point to the Special Intelligence Branch (SIB) and the Greyhounds—elite anti-Maoist commandos—as templates for moving from conventional policing to intelligence-led, target-based operations. The November 2025 encounter killing of senior Naxal commander Madvi Hidma in the forests of Andhra Pradesh dealt a major blow.

But by mid-2025, the security establishment had recognised that not all remaining Naxals could be neutralised. The strategy pivoted to surrenders, with states actively competing to bring cadres in with the help of civil society members, journalists and local leaders. The October 2025 surrender of top commander Mallojula Venugopal Rao, alias Bhupathi, marked a major breakthrough. Surrendering cadres, Shah said, are eligible for reward announced for their capture, released after a probation period. In the interim, they receive a monthly stipend of Rs 10,000 for three years, along with a one-time grant of Rs 50,000 for senior cadres, housing under the PM Awas scheme, and additional payments for weapons surrendered. Skill training is built in to aid reintegration. IG B. Sumathi, chief of Telangana's SIB, who has overseen more than 720 surrenders since 2024, stresses that the aim goes beyond disarmament: to see them "laying down their ideology, and not just arms, to embrace democracy".

Shah repeatedly underscored in Parliament that Naxalism was not merely a law-and-order issue but one rooted in governance deficits. The response has been a push to extend state presence into previously inaccessible areas. Since 2014, more than Rs 20,000 crore has been spent on roads in affected regions, with over 12,000 km completed. Mobile connectivity has expanded through 5,000 new towers, with another 8,000 sanctioned for rollout. In Bastar, security camps housing paramilitary personnel now double as service hubs—running schools for nearby villages, distributing rations and essentials, and providing basic healthcare. Welfare saturation drives, such as Chhattisgarh's Niyad Nellanaar scheme, aim to ensure access to identity documents, food support and banking services.

BEYOND THE ENDGAME

Yet, the ground reality remains more complex. Residual pockets of insurgency persist, particularly along inter-state borders, with ambushes and improvised explosive devices (IEDs) still posing a potent threat. In 2025, around 900 IEDs were detected in Chhattisgarh, with another 300–400 believed to be planted across roads, culverts and forest tracks. On March 1, an assistant commandant of the elite CoBRA unit lost his leg in an IED blast in Jharkhand.

What comes next is equally critical. Specialised units such as Chhattisgarh's District Reserve Guard, raised for counter-insurgency in 2008, will need careful redeployment; disbanding them risks creating new gaps. One proposal is to utilise these forces to staff newly built police stations across Bastar.

Reintegration poses another challenge. Many who have surrendered carry long histories of violence. The Chhattisgarh government has formed a cabinet sub-committee to review pending cases against surrendered cadres. It can recommend withdrawals, but no cases have been dropped so far.

Critics warn against premature victory claims. Devendra Gawande, a Maharashtra-based journalist and author of *Naxalwadache Avhaan* (The Challenge of Naxalism), says the conditions that fuelled the movement—poverty and social inequality—continue to persist in tribal regions. For now, the balance of evidence suggests that the insurgency, as it once existed, has been fundamentally dismantled. Whether this marks a definitive end will depend on what follows after the guns fall silent. ■

—with Amitabh Srivastava, Prasad Nichenametla and Dhaval S. Kulkarni